Copyright Statement

The Fillius Jazz Archive at Hamilton College has made a reasonable effort to secure permission from the interviewees to make these materials available to the public. Use of these materials by other parties is subject to the fair use doctrine in United States copyright law (Title 17, Chapter 1, section 107), which states that use by “reproduction in copies or phonorecords or by any other means specified by that section [106 and 106A], for purposes such as criticism, comment, news reporting, teaching (including multiple copies for classroom use), scholarship, or research, is not an infringement of copyright."

Any use that does not fall within fair use must be cleared with the rights holder. For assistance in contacting the rights holder please contact the Fillius Jazz Archive, Hamilton College, 198 College Hill Road, Clinton, NY 13323 (phone: 315-859-4071).

Lionel Hampton

Lionel Hampton's huge contribution to jazz should not be understated. As a band leader he was responsible for some of the era's most treasured recordings and his band helped to launch the careers of many future stars. While he first excelled on the drums, it was the vibraphone that will forever be associated with Lionel Hampton. He first played it with Louis Armstrong, when neither he nor Louis really knew what the instrument was. Lionel's vibraphone playing defines the essence of swing, and his enthusiasm on stage is hard to match.

Born in Louisville, Kentucky in 1913, he took drum lessons from a Franciscan nun and found his first important jazz experience with the Les Hite band in 1930. The Hite group was chosen to black up Louis Armstrong on his California tour and the recording of "Memories of You" with Satchmo in 1930 started his career as a vibraphonist. Lionel went on to greater fame with The Benny Goodman Big Band and Quartet and his own dynamic ensemble. Virtually all of the major soloists in jazz have played with "Hamp" and he continues to record and perform today.

Lionel was interviewed in New York City by Monk Rowe on October 18, 1995.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe and we are filming today for the Hamilton College Jazz Archive, and it is a special day for us today because we have with us one of the giants of jazz, master of the vibraphone and drums, Mr. Lionel Hampton. Thank you so much for joining us.

LH: Thank you, Monk.

MR: It is an extreme pleasure to have you here. And I'd like to start out and ask you about this, one of your more recent recording efforts here. This is a great effort here and I think the title, "For the Love of Music" really sums up perhaps what a lot of your life has been like, and it must have been interesting to record with fellows like Stevie Wonder. And I think that they were probably really happy to make a record with you.

LH: Yes. I'll tell you, it was quite an ordeal having these great stars to work with me. Well that's what I've been working with all my life. But I started out when I was a youngster, at 17 years old I used to be a drummer for Louis Armstrong.

MR: Out on the west coast?

LH: Yeah. And that was just like heaven. Playing with Louis Armstrong was a great big ordeal.

MR: Was it true that you were taught to play the drums by a nun?

LH: Yes. I'll tell you, I was raised up in Chicago. And the school system there was kind of rough. The kids were rebelling against everything that was going on in the community. They was having gang fights after school. If you were on the right side of the street —

MR: I guess things haven't changed that much today, you know?

LH: That's right. If you were on your side of the street, and another gang comes over, well you were lucky if you got home all right. But you see my grandmother wanted to see that I got an education and that I was always on the right side of the street. But as I tell you, at that time you were having gang fights in Chicago, so my grandmother picked out and inquired about a private school, and I was admitted there to a Catholic boy's training school. And in the schooling, well first of all, this place that I went in the school was a Catholic seminary. And it had Dominican sisters who were our teachers and also taught musical instruments. So the school was forming a drum & bugle corps and I picked up the drums, I always wanted to beat the drums. And so a sister taught me the rudiments of the drum. She was very, very good. You see drummers, they have scales too, and they're called the rudiments. The rudiments of drums. And so Sister Pietro was her name, and boy she was a great teacher. You know you were supposed play the scale of the drums, and they called it the paradiddles.

MR: Was she pretty strict with you?

LH: Yeah, well I'll tell you she was very strict. But she was good. I use that, she taught me, the system that she taught then, a lot of times I hardly read on drums, and play the right paradiddles, it was unbelievable. And if I didn't play the right paradiddles, she would almost point at you, over everybody, and she knew where to put them at. And if you can play the right paradiddles as I said.

MR: Well when you got out of school and you went to California and then you were playing with Les Hite? Is that right? And then Louis came out and you were supporting his group and he was playing with you.

LH: No. Les Hite is a guy that I knew around Chicago when we was kids coming up. And Les Hite was a really good saxophone player. And he got out in California and he wrote me to come out there with him. And then I could get a chance to play in the band. So I did and I wrote back and told him, and my grandmother let me come, and I told him I'd be out there to join the band.

MR: How old were you then?

LH: Huh?

MR: How old were you then?

LH: I was just about 18. And so my grandmother said — it happened that my aunt was going to California anyway because she had secured a job to work for one of the biggest stars in Hollywood, and so my grandmother told me if I stayed with my aunt and finished my schooling that I could go. So I had a chance to go out in California and Louis Armstrong, there's a story about Louis Armstrong. The place, the big night club out there where all the big movie stars and the jet set came to see the black shows and hear the black jazz

music. So they were having bands to do auditions to play behind Louis Armstrong, who was coming out to be the star, at this place called Frank Sebastian's Cotton Club. And so we did an audition and Louis' manager liked us so we got the job. So Louis Armstrong was in New York with his band, but he was trying to be commercialized, and picking a band out to play behind Louis. And this Les Hite's band was a bunch of youngsters, and we all could read music like mad, and we could play like mad. We had a terrific band. And so Louis Armstrong came out and he liked us so well back then that they took him on a recording session with him, and when we got to the recording session, there was a set of vibes in the corner of the studio. And Louis asked me what was the name of the instrument and I told him it was a new instrument and that this had been added to the percussion family, and they called it a vibraharp. One company makes this instrument, and they called it a vibraharp. Then another company made the same instrument and they called it the vibraphone.

MR: Did you actually record with it that day?

LH: Yes. So that day that, well I'll tell you it was the funniest story that happened, a funny incident. Louis asked me did I know anything about the instrument, and could I play it. But what happened was I looked the instrument over and the vibraphone, the one in the studio, the vibraphone, Louis asked me could I play something on it? And I said, "sure." I had never played on a vibraphone in my life. But I was a brazen young kid, and I looked on the vibraphone and saw it had the same keyboard that the xylophone had. And when I was still a young kid around Chicago, I played in the newspaper boy's band for, it was a black newspaper called the *Chicago Defender*, a newspaper. And it happened that Mr. Abbott, who owned the paper, said, "if you ever become a newspaper boy, and peddle my papers when they come out every Friday, and if you can join the band, we'll let you have an instrument and give you lessons." All this free. So I had played the drums in the marching band, but they had a symphony orchestra. I was in the band and I played the drums and tympanis and I was very lucky enough to play the xylophone.

MR: So you had a little head start when it came to the vibes.

LH: We really started, because when we went to rehearsals we got through rehearsals and, which we did, and if you became a newspaper boy, you had to practice, I think it was three times a week. And so in between, after, we'd go to music school, where the Chicago newspaper boys rehearsed at, and they had some xylophones there, and I would play the solos that I had taken off the records that was played by Louis Armstrong and Coleman Hawkins and Benny Goodman. And it ended up that I liked it a lot. I would practice and play note for note what these stars played.

MR: So you're really developing your ears for music.

LH: So I got a little head start on jazz, see? So I played something for a song that Louis had made a record on, called "Chinese Chop Suey." And Louis liked it so well, he said, "I'll tell you, you keep the vibraphone out there, and we're going to have you record with us." So Eubie Blake, the big solo player and piano player at that time sent Louis arrangements to record for him. And the name of the tune was "Memories of You."

MR: A beautiful song.

LH: Yeah, a beautiful song, yes. And so I played on the record, and people was wondering what instrument it was that they heard. And the vibes got very popular on the gig. And I found a new career.

MR: Yeah. Took off from then, didn't it?

LH: Yeah.

MR: Because you got — your quartet started playing around California? And eventually that led to meeting Teddy Wilson and Benny Goodman?

LH: Yes.

MR: So it's funny how things in your childhood will work. The fact that you got a little experience on that xylophone really paid off later on.

LH: Yeah. Real big. And about the big band, you know I joined Benny Goodman after Louis Armstrong. And we were the first integrated group, the first black and white group.

MR: Was that ever a problem playing in certain parts of the country?

LH: No, no. People [inaudible], because we all played good music. And Benny presented us in a professional way. We were a part of his organization, and it would be noticeable that we were soft. And the people liked that. Some of the ovations that we used to get, it was the sound.

MR: I thought it was interesting that that quartet didn't use a bass player a lot.

LH: No. Because Teddy Wilson played it in the left hand.

MR: He had a left hand like crazy.

LH: Yeah.

MR: When was the first time you recorded, or when did you write the tune "Flyin' Home?" Do you remember that?

LH: Yes, I wrote that "Flyin' Home" we were in California with Benny Goodman's band playing engagements out there, and all at once while we was out there in California, we got notice from the booking office, Benny did, that they wanted him in Atlantic City for a tremendous amount of money. They wanted him to play on the Steel Pier. And then Benny didn't have no way to get there but to fly, to fly his whole aggregation there. And so none of us had flown on a plane before. So I was sitting there next to Benny and I kept humming this song, the melody of "Flyin' Home." So Benny said, "well what's that

you're humming?" I said, "I'm just making it up to keep myself amused." I never flew before, and I'm trying to keep myself company.

MR: I think it's great because that tune has followed you through your career, and here it is on a CD from 1991 or '93, and another version of it. That's fascinating.

LH: The guy that's playing the tenor part on there, it goes on the jacket there that he plays the tenor part, naturally will become very famous. It's a guy by the name of Josh Redman. And he's a guy that's making a whole lot of noise now with his saxophone playing. And he's playing on this. I'd like to say that that's one of the finest saxophone solos I've heard.

MR: He comes from a line of saxophone players doesn't he. His father, Josh? His father is Dewey Redman, right?

LH: Yeah?

MR: Yeah. His father is a fine saxophone player too.

LH: He was, huh?

MR: Yeah. Dewey Redman.

LH: He [Joshua] went to Harvard, didn't he?

MR: Yes he did.

LH: He went to be a lawyer, didn't he?

MR: I think so.

LH: And came out a saxophone player.

MR: Wow. That's interesting.

LH: That's a switch.

MR: Yeah, oh man. And when you, in your big band when you got associated with RCA Records, the people that you played with, that played with you, I mean it's an amazing list. It's almost like the only people that didn't play with you were your direct competition I guess, you know like Count Basie I suppose. Was there a big, like a very competitive scene with the big bands at that time?

LH: No, more like a society.

MR: A society, yeah.

LH: The first time, you know I had a contract with RCA Victor to make all sorts of jazz records. And you speak about the different characters. And you know the first time the beboppers ever played, I had Dizzy Gillespie, and that's where he played, bebop. "Hot Mallets" did you ever hear that record?

MR: Which record?

LH: Called "Hot Mallets."

MR: "Hot Mallets."

LH: They did a terrific job on that. And a whole lot of guys. I had Johnny Hodges at one time.

MR: Oh, gee. You picked guys from the Basie band to come in and then from the Ellington band.

LH: Yeah, the Ellington band. You know just before we went into the studio, we did a record called "Sunny Side of the Street." And Johnny Hodges played a lead solo on it. And the record got to be a big hit. And Duke Ellington passed a rule that none of his men could record for anybody else. He told Johnny, "if it's going to be a hit, don't go to nobody else."

MR: Save it for my band right?

LH: Save it for my band.

MR: Duke didn't have enough hits huh?

LH: Huh?

MR: Duke didn't have enough hits to make him happy, he wanted some of yours. Who would write some of the arrangements for those recordings?

LH: Well, they'd be mostly heads.

MR: Mostly head arrangements.

LH: Maybe an ensemble, last chorus, something like that. We'd have a different one, make an ensemble or last chorus, but most of it was all heads you know. And a long time ago, I just can't think of the name of the people.

MR: When you had the big band out on the road, it must have been pretty hard to keep so many guys together and happy. Was that a tough job being a leader of a big band.

LH: I tell you, I was always lucky. Because I was always seeking the fine youngsters, you know. They want to be musicians, and was waiting for a break to play in a big band. Because big bands was very popular then, just like when I left Benny Goodman and went out to get my band, there was little kids walking around in California, where I was staying at, after I left Benny Goodman, he took sick. And the doctors who were at the place warned him not to play no more for six months, because he had a disease called sciatica. I think it's some back trouble. And I was out in Los Angeles when Benny Goodman had resigned from his playing for the next six months. And I had a home out there in Los Angeles, and I said well Benny told me to go and start my band. He said, "don't let this get away from you and be idle, for you've got a good start." He said, "form a band and go out and see what you can do." So I started to get the guys together, and I got all these unknown youngsters. Illinois Jacquet, he was just a young guy trying to make it with a band out in Los Angeles. And there was Dexter Gordon, he came and auditioned for me and when he came to audition for me he came in with a clarinet wrapped up in newspaper. So I played some chords for him on the piano and he played

the clarinet. Well I told him I said "I want you to play tenor." So finally my wife, my late wife, Gladys, had got a guy and went down to the [sounds like] Lucky Music Company. That's where all the musicians traded with, and gave him a tenor saxophone, and then we had Marshall Royal, who was a great saxophone player. Marshall, when his brother was coming up, Ernie Royal, Ernie Royal could play really high notes on trumpet.

MR: Did you put him on lead then?

LH: Yeah, he played lead. And I got Lee Young, who was Lester Young's brother, playing drums with me. And I kept picking up men like that until I picked up a 16 piece band. And so I got some arrangements from a guy by the name of Joey Williams, who had a book of arrangements, and I got, and he was a terrific arranger. The first arrangement that, oh, what's the big band leader's name? What I'm going to tell you, you're going to be shocked. Glenn Miller. This guy arranged for Glenn Miller. Because it wasn't Glenn Miller's idea, it was this guy's idea, his name was Joey Williams.

MR: For the way the reed section worked?

LH: Yeah. It was Joey Williams. But George Williams, see I didn't pick out the classic arrangements that he had arranged for Glenn Miller, I picked out the jazz arrangements. So George Williams, I got those arrangements from Williams, and the funny thing about it, we got these arrangements at $10 a piece. At $10 a piece. Because Joe Glaser, a big booker, well he wanted to secure my band, and I put a price and I said you can have it if you give me ten thousand dollars in advance. Well the arrangements were so cheap, that I got about 50 arrangements and oh, I got a whole lot of them for that. And I took the rest of the money and bought my wife a mink coat.

MR: Good deal. I'll bet she liked that deal too.

LH: Yeah.

MR: So your band was like a training ground for very many young musicians.

LH: Yeah. And later down the line I got Quincy Jones, and I almost had Ray Charles, because Quincy Jones and Ray Charles were doing gigs together in Seattle, Washington. And I got Quincy Jones and he was making arrangements for the band, and then I picked up the piano player, what was his name, oh boy, Milt Buckner. Milt Buckner. You know he plays a lot of kinds of style of piano.

MR: Yeah. He's a good organist too.

LH: Yeah. A great organist. And let me see here. Oh, Joe Williams?

MR: Joe Williams? There's a name we like.

LH: I'm going to tell you about that deal. When I was looking for a girl singer, and I got to Chicago, the band had been popular, but the band was always popular because I was popular, and I could carry the band myself because I was the first black musician to play in a white band. See and Teddy Wilson was playing with Benny, but he used to play

when Benny used to take intermission, and no white musicians was on stage, then Teddy would play, by himself see? So I was the first one, legally to break that tradition down. But you know the funny thing about it, there wasn't no black and white playing together no place. Not in pictures, moving pictures, not in baseball, or football, no kind of sports. The Benny Goodman quartet was the first mixed group and it was, you know? So I was playing in Chicago at the Regal Theater, that's the black theater on the south side of Chicago, where all the big name black acts and name bands would play at. So Joe Glaser got there ahead of me, and a friend of his named Joe Sherman that owned the Sherman Bar where all the sailors from Great Lakes used to come to his place and drink, and it was 25 cents a beer, and hear jazz. At that time they had a great trumpet player that used to play with Earl "Fatha" Hines' band, oh, what was that trumpet player's name. If I called his name you would know it.

MR: Jabbo Smith?

LH: The trumpet player.

MR: No, I'm sorry, but you were talking about Joe Williams.

LH: Oh yeah, Joe Williams came into the story. So Joe Glaser came and he told me this friend, Joe Sherman that owned this Sherman Bar & Grill, he told him he was looking for a girl singer for me. So Joe Sherman said, "Well come down and I'll have my girl in the washroom sing something. You'll see how she sounds. She sounds pretty good to me." And that's what Joe said to Joe Glaser. And I'm trying to think of the trumpet player too that had the band, he had a really hot band, about six or seven pieces. So Joe Glaser went down that night and heard her sing. He came back and told me, "She sounded all right to me." So Joe Glaser invited her to come out to the Regal Theater. And we used to do four shows out there at the Regal Theater, two in the afternoon and two at night. And we had people lined up two blocks to get in to the theater. But they didn't have no place to go. Black people didn't have no place to go for their own places, you understand? Those days for them, of course, they didn't go downtown to the white theaters, and they came to the neighborhood theater, and they got big entertainment. Because all the big bands were out there, and also all the black entertainers, singers and dancers and so forth. So the girl from the washroom came out to the theater and sang for me, and I heard her sing, and I said she broke it up, with the crowd. I said to her, "I sure do like your singing." I said, "Would you like to join the band?" And she said, "Yes, I'd like to join the band." Naturally she would say it for we were the hottest band in the country at that time. And so I said, "Well tell me what's your name?" She said, "My name is Ruth Jones." I said, "I like your singing, but I don't like that name." I said, "Can I change your name?" She said, "I don't care what you call me, as long as you give me the job to sing with you." I said, "from now on your name is Dinah Washington." Out of the clear blue sky I said

that. The guy that was standing next to me, because he was a friend of the manager of the Regal Theater where I was playing at, said, "oh, there goes my chance, I wanted to sing with the band." So I said, "You can sing at the next show, because we're going to do two matinees." And I said, "What's your name?" He said, "My name is Joe Williams." I said, "Well okay, you can sing." So I hired him and for two years I had Dinah Washington and Joe Williams for a boy and girl singer.

MR: Wow. That's quite a line-up.

LH: Yes it was. They'd sing everything off the map. Because they was great singers. So that's the Joe Williams story.

MR: Did you ever have occasion to have your band play opposite the other great groups, like Ellington or Basie?

LH: Yeah, we played against Basie at the Savoy Ballroom in New York. And I don't want to be stuck up, in no kind of way, but we ran Basie out of the hole that night.

MR: Ran 'em out, huh? Well you guys had quite a show too, I mean, you were great showmen as well as great musicians, right?

LH: Yeah. We put on a show.

MR: That's great.

LH: And we had all guys coming from different places in the country and was playing like mad, because this was the first time they had a chance to show off.

MR: They wanted to make their mark.

LH: Yeah, and me too. It was a great band.

MR: And since then you've been around the world spreading jazz all over, right?

LH: Yeah.

MR: Been an ambassador of jazz so to speak.

LH: Yeah. We had our fill of it.

MR: What was one of your most memorable places to play in another country?

LH: When they picked us out to be the first band to play the White House. Yep. That was for President Truman.

MR: That's wonderful.

LH: We played his inaugural ball. And played a concert at the White House the night before, and then, the night before we played a concert, and Lena Horne was our singer. I think we had two singers that night — Lena Horne and I can't think of her name. But she was very popular, a popular singer.

MR: And tell me about the group you have right now, the Golden Men of Jazz.

LH: Oh, the Golden Men of Jazz, we're at the Blue Note next week, and we have such outstanding players, well we have Frank Foster, who has just left from directing the Basie

band, he's going to play with us. Frank wants to write a symphony. He's got a lot of work ahead to do.

MR: Get off the road for a while.

LH: That's right, get off the road for a while. Right. You're right. And we've got oh, who is the saxophone player? Have you got the list there?

MR: Buddy Tate?

LH: Buddy Tate is not playing. But maybe it will come to me after. We've got Sweets Edison playing one trumpet, and we've got Al Grey playing trombone and oh, this is all changed up.

MR: Yeah. You've got Junior Mance on piano?

LH: Yeah, Junior Mance on piano. And let me see. We've got the drummer, we've got, let's see, oh, well.

MR: You're going to be rehearsing with them next week? I'll bet it will be a great thing.

LH: It's quite a group. That's quite a group. It's so wonderful to have Frank Foster, a very talented musician.

MR: Yes he is. And a great gentleman.

LH: Yes he's a great gentleman and a great soloist.

MR: It's marvelous that Monday you were able to be part of this photo shoot for *Life* magazine too, re-staging that photo?

LH: Yes.

MR: That's great.

LH: But I want to say that music is getting serious now. And you can hear some of the best jazz that you've ever heard now that the musicians are well prepared, they're well schooled and they have experience, and you just can get a good insight on what they can do with their talent.

MR: So you think the future of jazz looks pretty good?

LH: I think so. I think jazz is going to get its rightful heritage and its home, with the talented jazz musicians we've got now. Because the guys are really going into the depths of music and are thinking and they're creating and they're doing great creations. And I think the public, if they listen, they're in for some good rivals, you understand? Because the musicians there is are talented enough and capable enough to give them the best in jazz.

MR: Well that's a very positive outlook. And on behalf of Hamilton College, I want to thank you for joining us today. This was just fascinating. And we really appreciate your time.

LH: Well I'm glad to do it for the College. That's Hamilton College.

MR: Hamilton College.

LH: Almost Hampton College.

MR: It just might be we'll have you up there and re-name the college. There's a friend of yours over there. Thank you so much.

LH: Thank you, too. And I want to say you know — this is more — I've been waiting to be interviewed by a gentleman of your caliber.